Word Formation

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Functional English (SS1012)

Word Formation

- Word formation is the process of creating new words from existing ones using various linguistic techniques. These processes are an essential aspect of morphology, the study of the structure of words.

1. Affixation (Derivation)

- This is one of the most common methods, involving the addition of prefixes (at the beginning) and suffixes (at the end) to a base or root word. Affixation can change the word's meaning or its part of speech.

Prefixation

Adding a prefix to the front of a word.

un- + happy → unhappy
re- + write → rewrite
mis- + understand → misunderstand

Suffixation

Adding a suffix to the end of a word.

kind + -ness → kindness
act + -or → actor
quick + -ly → quickly

2. Compounding

- This process combines two or more independent words (root morphemes) to create a single new word. The resulting compound word often has a new meaning that is related to its parts.

Closed compounds
Written as a single word.

rain + bow → rainbow
blue + berry → blueberry

Open compounds
Written as separate words.

high + school → high school
peanut + butter → peanut butter

Hyphenated compounds
Joined by a hyphen.

mother + in + law → mother-in-law
state + of + the + art → state-of-the-art

3. Clipping

- Clipping is the process of shortening a longer word by removing one or more syllables while retaining the core meaning. Clipped words are often used in informal contexts.

Back clipping: Removes the end of a word.

advertisement → ad
gymnasium → gym

Fore-clipping: Removes the beginning of a word.

telephone → phone
alligator → gator

Middle clipping: Retains the middle of the word.

influenza → flu

Complex clipping: Shortens a compound word.

situation comedy → sitcom

4. Blending

- Blending combines parts of two or more words to form a new word. It is similar to compounding, but instead of using entire words, only parts are merged.

  smoke + fog → smog
  breakfast + lunch → brunch
  web + log → blog

Confused between Complex Clipping and Blending?

Feature	Complex Clipping	Blending
Process	Shortening a word (clipping) sometimes combined with compounding.	Fusing parts of two (or more) words to make a new one.
Main Focus	Cutting off syllables or parts.	Merging overlapping sounds/letters.
Structure	Often a shortened compound.	Usually a creative mix of two words.
Examples	- *Sitcom* ← situation + comedy - *Netizen* ← internet + citizen	- *Brunch* ← breakfast + lunch - *Smog* ← smoke + fog
Resulting Word	Still shows link to original longer form or compound.	A new word that often sounds like one word.
Usage	Common in casual/short forms and tech culture.	Common in modern coinages, advertising, pop culture.

5. Back-formation

- This method creates a new word by removing a real or perceived affix from an existing word. It is the reverse of affixation and often changes the word's part of speech.

editor (noun) → edit (verb)
donation (noun) → donate (verb)

6. **Conversion (Zero Derivation)**

- Conversion is the process of changing a word's part of speech without adding any affixes. The word's form remains identical, but its function shifts.

  Verb to noun: to walk(verb) → a walk(noun)
  Noun to verb: access (noun) → to access (verb)

7. Coinage

- Coinage is the process of **inventing an entirely new word** (not by affixation, blending, clipping, or back-formation).
  - Often comes from **brand names** or **completely new creations**.
  - Many start as trademarks but become common words in everyday language.
    - **Google** → originally a company name, now also means "to search online."
    - **Kleenex** → brand name for tissues, now used generically.
    - **Xerox** → photocopy (from the company name).
    - **Aspirin**, **Teflon**, **Vaseline** → all started as brand names.
    - **Kodak** → a purely invented word (no prior meaning).

8. Acronyms and Initialisms

- This process forms a new word from the initial letters of a series of words.

Acronym: An abbreviation pronounced as a word.

NASA (National Aeronautics and Space Administration)
FAST (Foundation for Advancement of Science & Technology)

Initialism: An abbreviation read letter by letter.

FBI (Federal Bureau of Investigation)
USA (United States of America)

Why Sometimes Dots Appear in Initialism?

- Historically, **dots** were used to show that letters were "missing."
- Older style: **U.S.A.**, **U.N.**, **I.B.M.**
- Modern style: **USA**, **UN**, **IBM** (dots dropped for simplicity, especially in digital/media writing).

So, the difference is mainly:

1.Style convention / formality

1. Academic or older texts → often use dot (*U.S.A.*).
2. Modern, tech, journalistic writing → usually no dots (*USA*).

2.Ease of reading & branding

1. Organizations prefer clean, dot-free forms (e.g., NASA, NATO, FIFA).

3.Regional variation

1. American English historically kept dots more often.
2. British English dropped them earlier.

9. Borrowing

- Borrowing (or loaning) is the process of adopting words from another language directly into English.

  pizza (from Italian)
  solo (from Italian)
  algebra (from Arabic)

10. Reduplication

- This process creates a new word by repeating a word or a part of a word.

Rhyming reduplication: hocus-pocus
Repetition with vowel change: chitchat
Repetition without change: bye-bye